

to merely 47 ms and drops the end-to-end latency to 94 ms. I felt no noticeable audio-video lag when using this mode. There's also the Earbud Fit Test in the app that discerns if the eartips you're using have provided an airtight fit.

Lastly, the app also lets you customise every single control. So, By default, there are no volume controls mapped to the touch panels, but I customised the controls so that the long press action lowers and increases the volume levels on the left and right panels respectively. I'm glad OPPO has incorporated this level of customisability since many don't – sometimes at even double the price. As I said, tons of features!

PERFORMANCE

Equipped with 12.4 mm dynamic drivers, the OPPO Enco Air3 Pro sounds excellent for the price. According to OPPO, these earbuds are the first in the world to use a bamboo fibre diaphragm which can easily reproduce high frequencies. The earbuds have a frequency response range of 20 Hz - 40,000 Hz – which is higher than the human hearing range, but this does help reduce the drop-off in the highs. OPPO also claims that since the bamboo diaphragm is much lighter in comparison to titanium-plated ones, it can be driven more easily.

The company has also added high-quality LDAC codec support – a massive rarity at this price! This codec allows 990 kbps transmission speeds over Bluetooth which is almost triple that of the SBC codec, allowing for more high-res sound which is close to CD quality.

All of this innovation shows merit when you listen to these earbuds for the first time. The sound signature is beautifully balanced in the bass and mids and the highs have a bit of a boost to bring out sounds such as cymbals and hi-hats that are usually lost in the mix. The sound signature graph also shows that the earphones have a superb and balanced bass response that complements the mids very well, ensuring that one frequency doesn't overpower the other.

The highs from 2kHz to 8kHz have a boost and the sound signature is quite

bright, by default. However, they also work to bring out oodles of detail in tracks such as Pull Me Under by Dream Theatre. In this track, the detail and clarity of the high-frequency instruments in usually lost in cheap earphones (under ₹5,000), but that's definitely not the case here. Comparing these earbuds to the OnePlus Buds Z2, you can hear how much detail you lose out on in the mids (where most vocals lie) since the bass response is quite bloated. However, do note, that the highs can get a bit fatiguing to listen to after long periods of listening.

This is not the case with the OPPO Enco Air3 Pro since they emphasize the vocals in a clear manner by balancing the bass. The trick is to tune the earphones in such a manner that the bass and mids are symbiotic, and do not cannibalise each other, which is what the Enco Air3 Pro does so well. This sound signature is not something that we'd call commercial. It will not appeal to the masses that love bass-forward sound signatures – but if you're a purist who's looking to get your hands on a relatively cheap pair of TWS under ₹5K, this is a great starting point.

Moving on to the microphones, it is decent but nothing to write home about. The earphones pack dual microphones with AI noise reduction technology that attempts to reduce ambient noise when on calls. However, it doesn't do the best job at this. It is on par with other TWS at this price – you can make decent calls when you're indoors with minimal distractions, but when there's a lot of ambient noise, the person on the other end of the call will be able to hear a lot of it.

BATTERY LIFE

The OPPO Enco Air3 Pro houses 43 mAh batteries in each earbud and a 440 mAh cell in the charging case. This translates to 7 hours of playback time on the earbuds and 30 hours of total battery life, as claimed by OPPO. Do note these numbers are with ANC turned off and with AAC audio in use. In my testing, I did quite the opposite. Active Noise Cancellation was turned on pretty much all the time and I was using the LDAC codec. So, naturally, the numbers I got in my

testing were much lower. So, the earbuds lasted a little under 4.5 hours in my tests, and the charging case provided 3 full charges after that with a little juice to spare (enough to charge the buds to about 60 per cent). The volume levels varied from 50-70 per cent. Your mileage will depend on whether you turn on ANC, use LDAC and the volume levels you listen at.

But all that being said, the battery life is still mediocre when compared to other options such as the OnePlus Nord Buds 2. Without ANC, the OnePlus Nord Buds 2 can provide up to 36 hours of total battery life – that's 6 whole hours more than the OPPO Enco Air3 Pro.

VERDICT

The OPPO Enco Air3 Pro is the best-sounding pair of TWS earphones under ₹5,000. There is no questioning that. It blows competition such as the Realme Buds Air 3 and the OnePlus Buds Z2 out of the water because of its honest representation of the bass and mid frequencies. The sound signature is bright and sparkly and will appeal to audiophiles, especially those who are just getting acquainted with audiophile-grade audio devices and want to purchase a good, inexpensive pair of TWS for themselves. The earbuds are also extremely feature-rich, however, OPPO needs to work on its ANC game and the lack of a customisable EQ in the HeyMelody app just seems like a missed opportunity. However, all of the nitpicks can be set aside and forgotten given that the sound is just incredible. If you have ₹5,000 to spare, pick these up now! Unless you clearly prefer bass-forward earphones – if that's the case, pick the Realme Buds Air 3.

–Dhriti Datta

SPECIFICATIONS

Driver: 12.4 mm dynamic unit | Driver sensitivity: 107dB @1KHz | Frequency response range: 20~40KHz | Bluetooth codecs: LDAC, AAC, SBC | Bluetooth version: 5.3 | Bluetooth range: 10 m / 33 feet | Battery life: 7 hours (earbuds), 30 hours (buds + case) without ANC | Charging time: 1.5 hours (earbuds) | IP rating: IP55 dust and water resistant | Weight: 4.3 g (each bud)

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